

Dr. Salvador Roquet

1920-1995

A pioneering Mexican psychiatrist known for integrating traditional Mazatec practices with modern psychotherapy.



Image via [Asociación Española de Axiología](#)

Born in 1920 in Tierra Blanca, Veracruz, Salvador Roquet was a notable psychiatrist known for integrating indigenous Mazatec practices with modern psychotherapy. His early use of psychedelics in therapy was innovative and sparked considerable controversy and debate regarding the ethical implications of his method.

By 36, Roquet had earned notable academic qualifications, including a master's degree in public health with a specialization in malariology, and later, a specialization in neurology at Gea González Hospital. He held prominent public positions, leading the National Campaigns against Malaria and Tuberculosis from 1951 to 1955. Following a political setback, he transitioned to psychiatry, where he focused on exploring the therapeutic potential of altered states of consciousness.¹

His interest in the therapeutic potential of altered states of consciousness soon became central to his practice. In the 1960s, Roquet founded the Institute of Psychosynthesis in Mexico City (Instituto de Psicosisíntesis). Here, he integrated the use of hallucinogenic substances like LSD, psilocybin, mescaline, psilocybin mushrooms, peyote, and datura into psychotherapy.

Roquet also directed the Albert Schweitzer Cultural Organization, which supported a humanistic school for patients' children, emphasizing creativity and emotional well-being. He further expanded his impact by establishing a

¹Rodiles, Janine. "Psicoterapia Prohibida del Doctor Roquet." Liberaddictus AC, November 1, 1996. Accessed via Calle Molinos núm. 20 Int. 8, Colonia Mixcoac, Delegación Benito Juárez, Ciudad de México. <https://www.liberaddictus.org/varios/334-psicoterapia-prohibida-del-doctor-roquet.html>.

hospital in the mountains of Oaxaca, demonstrating his commitment to integrating holistic care into remote and underserved communities.²

Roquet collaborated with María Sabina, an indigenous Mazatec curandera renowned for her knowledge of mushrooms. This partnership aimed to bridge indigenous healing traditions and modern psychotherapy, although it faced criticism for potential cultural appropriation and ethical concerns. Sabina's deep understanding of sacred mushrooms was central to the work of Roquet, which sought to harness the healing potential of these plants within a structured therapeutic framework. Sabina, who lived in the remote village of Huautla de Jiménez in Oaxaca, preserved the ancient Mazatec tradition of using psilocybin mushrooms in healing ceremonies. These mushrooms have been used for centuries by indigenous peoples for their psychoactive properties.³

Roquet's therapy sessions were created to be deeply immersive and transformative. They involved administering psychedelic substances, followed by a "sensory overload show" of lights, sounds, and intense imagery. To alleviate the anxiety caused by these experiences, Roquet administered ketamine hydrochloride, which he used to help smooth the patients' transitions as the effects of the other psychedelics wore off. He employed a combination of psychedelic drugs and an array of sensory stimuli, including music, films, and images, to evoke emotional responses.

Participants would lay down in a controlled setting designed to maximize comfort and minimize external distractions, often with evocative artwork and sensory elements surrounding them. Influenced by the Mazatec tradition of using psilocybin mushrooms in night-time ceremonies, Roquet's sessions

²Alberto Villoldo, "An Introduction to the Psychedelic Psychotherapy of Salvador Roquet," *Journal of Humanistic Psychology* 17, no. 4 (1977): 45-58.

<https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/abs/10.1177/002216787701700406?journalCode=jhpa>.

³See, for example, Friedlander, *Being Indian*; Deloria, *Playing Indian*; Huhndorf, *Going Native*; Fikes, Carlos Castaneda; Agustín, *La contracultura*, 45-46; Sluis, "Journeys to Others," 1-9, 14. Michael F. Brown, *Who Owns Culture?*; Cadena and Starn, "Introduction," 1-30, in *Indigenous Experience Today*; Tsing, "Indigenous Voice"; Clifford, "Varieties"; Rappaport, *Intercultural Utopias*; Tsing, "From the Margins." Quoted in Alexander S. Dawson, "Salvador Roquet, María Sabina, and the Trouble with Jipis," *Hispanic American Historical Review* 95, no. 1 (February 1, 2015): 104,

<https://read.dukeupress.edu/hahr/article-abstract/95/1/103/36388/Salvador-Roquet-Maria-Sabina-and-the-Trouble-with?redirectedFrom=fulltext>.

typically began at night. His goal was to facilitate deep psychological transformations by accessing subconscious realms, which he believed were typically inaccessible through traditional methods. This method, detailed in his book *Los Alucinógenos de la Concepción Indígena a una Nueva Psicoterapia*, aimed to access the deep layers of the subconscious where unresolved issues reside.⁴

Roquet believed that beneath the surface of the conscious mind lies a "roaring river of instinct and feeling" often suppressed by modern life. His therapy aimed to help people reconnect with intense, often ignored emotions, reigniting their sense of life, discovery, and wonder. By integrating powerful sensory stimuli, Roquet aimed to create an environment where patients could confront and process these deep-seated emotional currents, facilitating healing and personal growth.⁵

"Roquet utilized various hallucinogenic drugs, including LSD, psilocybin, mescaline, datura, and ketamine. Known as 'a master of bad trips,' and 'a pusher of death,' Roquet subjected people to adverse stimuli while they were drugged"⁶

Roquet's approach to psychedelic therapy was rooted in a convivial, group session framework. He designed these sessions to be both intensive and communal, believing that a collective experience could enhance the therapeutic process. Each session typically lasted around 22 hours, during which participants were administered psychodysleptics under close supervision. About eight days later, a follow-up group therapy session lasting approximately 8 hours was held without psychedelics. In the following weeks, patients continued their therapeutic journey by attending weekly individual

⁴Philip E. Wolfson, "Psychedelic Experiential Pharmacology: Pioneering Clinical Explorations with Salvador Roquet (How I Came to All of This: Ketamine, Admixtures and Adjuvants, Don Juan and Carlos Castaneda Too): An Interview with Richard Yensen," *International Journal of Transpersonal Studies* 33, no. 2 (2014): 160-174, <https://doi.org/10.24972/ijts.2014.33.2.160>.

⁵Dr. Abraham Sussman, quoted in Goldhill, Olivia. "What a Bad Trip Can Teach You." *The Cut*. December 8, 2021. <https://www.thecut.com/2021/12/cover-story-podcast-bad-hug.html>.

⁶Martin A. Lee and Bruce Shlain, *Acid Dreams: The Complete Social History of LSD: The CIA, the Sixties, and Beyond* (New York: Grove Press, 1994) <https://groveatlantic.com/book/acid-dreams/>.

sessions with the therapist, observing other sessions, or participating in the latter stages of other groups' sessions.⁷

Roquet's innovative methods extended beyond Mexico. In the fall of 1972, he traveled to the Maryland Psychiatric Research Center, an institution funded by the U.S. government, to present his group-therapy sessions. His visit aimed to offer experiential training to American clinicians interested in psychedelic psychotherapy. However, his methods encountered significant obstacles due to the escalating War on Drugs. By 1968, the U.S. government had outlawed LSD possession, and President Richard Nixon's 1971 declaration of a war on drugs brought increased scrutiny and legal pressures on psychedelic research.⁸

Furthermore, in 1974, reforms to the Mexican penal code increased punishments for possession of drugs such as LSD, peyote, and psilocybin mushrooms. On November 21, 1974, a police raid occurred at Roquet's clinic. Around 25 patients, doctors, and staff members were arrested, and Roquet, along with his associates Pierre Louis Favreau and Rubén Ocaña Soler, was detained the following morning. The raid uncovered various psychedelic substances, which authorities cited as evidence of Roquet's involvement in administering dangerous drugs believed to cause cerebral lesions.⁹

Authorities found documentation indicating Roquet collected fees for these drugs, contributing to charges of drug trafficking. Compounding his legal troubles, the raid also unearthed "pornographic" films, leading to additional charges of "moral turpitude." These discoveries led the Procuraduría General de la República (PGR) to label him a "charlatan," and a targeted smear

⁷Alexander Macmillan, "The 'Convivial' Psychotherapy Process of Dr. Salvador Roquet," PhD diss., University of Massachusetts Amherst, 1987, ProQuest Dissertations Publishing, <https://www.proquest.com/docview/303604648>. And Salvador Roquet and Pierre L. Favreau, *Los Alucinógenos de la Concepción Indígena a una Nueva Psicoterapia* (Mexico City: Ediciones Prisma, 1981), 66. <https://archive.org/details/alucinopsicoterapoooroqu/page/68/mode/2up>.

⁸Emily Witt, "Ketamine Therapy Is Going Mainstream. Are We Ready?" *The New Yorker*, December 29, 2021, <https://www.newyorker.com/culture/annals-of-inquiry/ketamine-therapy-is-going-mainstream-are-we-ready>.

⁹Alexander S. Dawson, "Salvador Roquet, María Sabina, and the Trouble with Jipis," *Hispanic American Historical Review* 95, no. 1 (February 1, 2015): 122, <https://read.dukeupress.edu/hahr/article-abstract/95/1/103/36388/Salvador-Roquet-Maria-Sabina-and-the-Trouble-with?redirectedFrom=fulltext>.

campaign ensued, reaching its peak with an article in *Tiempo* magazine four days after his arrest.¹⁰

Although the patients were quickly released, Roquet and his assistant Dr. Favreau were imprisoned for several weeks due to the seriousness of the charges. An organization of Roquet's former patients, led by influential Mexicans, rallied to his defense, and several distinguished American psychiatrists testified to the validity of his methods. Ultimately, Drs. Roquet and Favreau were cleared of the charges and allowed to reopen the Institute, shifting focus to visual and audio stimuli rather than psychedelics.¹¹

"After I left jail, I began to travel, giving workshops and lectures. We started doing simulated sessions, with the lights and sounds, without the drugs....We found that 90 percent of the people had reactions similar to those of people who had taken the drugs....We found that the psychedelics were nothing more than the launching pad, the nature of the sessions was conditioned by the other techniques we used."
(Roquet)¹²

Roquet's legacy is complicated by his collaboration with the Mexican secret police, Dirección Federal de Seguridad (DFS), during a tumultuous period in Mexico. He used his expertise in psychedelics to interrogate student activists, raising ethical questions about the misuse of psychiatric knowledge for state-led coercion. Roquet justified this method as a way to produce "better citizens," as noted in his court testimonies. His collaboration with the DFS earned him favor with government officials, allowing him to run his practice with minimal governmental interference until his arrest in 1974.¹³

¹⁰Dawson, Alexander S. "Peyote Outlawed in Mexico." In *The Peyote Effect: From the Inquisition to the War on Drugs*, 121-133. Berkeley: University of California Press, 2018.

<https://doi.org/10.1525/california/9780520285422.003.0011>.

¹¹Citation Clark, Walter Houston. "BAD TRIPS may be the BEST TRIPS." *FATE Magazine*, April 1976.

<https://www.psychedellic-library.org/clark2.htm>.

¹²Krippner, Stanley. "Salvador Roquet Remembered: An Innovative Psychedelic Therapist in 1960s Mexico." *Chacruna Institute*, 1 March 2017, <https://chacruna.net/salvador-roquet-remembered/>.

¹³Alexander S. Dawson, "Salvador Roquet, María Sabina, and the Trouble with Jipis," *Hispanic American Historical Review* 95, no. 1 (February 1, 2015): 123-124,

<https://read.dukeupress.edu/hahr/article-abstract/95/1/103/36388/Salvador-Roquet-Maria-Sabina-and-the-Trouble-with?redirectedFrom=fulltext>.

Dr. Salvador Roquet's therapeutic approaches, though controversial, provided transformative experiences for individuals facing profound struggles. Testimonials from patients such as Angélica Parragot Gronillet and Rosa María highlight the significant impact of Roquet's methods. Angélica, who was initially suicidal, experienced a remarkable transformation after 52 sessions, moving away from depression. Similarly, Rosa María, who struggled with substance abuse and depression, reported significant improvements following her treatment with Roquet. She successfully ceased using cocaine and eventually overcame her reliance on amphetamines, showcasing the potential of Roquet's therapies to facilitate profound personal change.¹⁴

Dr. Salvador Roquet's legacy is characterized by his pioneering and controversial approach to psychotherapy. He combined traditional Mazatec practices with modern psychiatry, using hallucinogens to explore the human psyche. Despite ethical concerns, Roquet continued his work, providing transformative experiences to many individuals. His therapeutic methods evolved over time, leading to the development of non-drug "convivials," which he directed until his death in 1995.¹⁵

PUBLICATIONS

- Salvador Roquet and Pierre Louis Favreau, [*Los Alucinógenos de la Concepción Indígena a una Nueva Psicoterapia*](#) (Mexico City: Ediciones Prisma, 1981).

COLLABORATORS

- María Sabína
- Pierre Louis Favreau
- Rubén Ocaña Soler
- Abraham Sussman
- Richard Yensen
- Stanislav Grof

¹⁴Alexander S. Dawson, "Salvador Roquet, María Sabína, and the Trouble with Jipis," *Hispanic American Historical Review* 95, no. 1 (February 1, 2015): 125-126, <https://read.dukeupress.edu/hahr/article-abstract/95/1/103/36388/Salvador-Roquet-Maria-Sabina-and-the-Trouble-with?redirectedFrom=fulltext>.

¹⁵Krippner, Stanley. "Salvador Roquet Remembered: An Innovative Psychedelic Therapist in 1960s Mexico." *Chacruna Institute*, 1 March 2017, <https://chacruna.net/salvador-roquet-remembered/>.

FURTHER READING

- [*Acid Dreams: The Complete Social History of LSD: The CIA, The Sixties, and Beyond*](#) by Martin A. Lee and Bruce Shlain
- ["An Introduction to the Psychedelic Psychotherapy of Salvador Roquet"](#) by Alberto Villoldo in the Journal of Humanistic Psychology
- ["Salvador Roquet, María Sabina, and the Trouble with Jipis"](#) by Alexander S. Dawson in the Hispanic American Historical Review
- ["Salvador Roquet Remembered: An Innovative Psychedelic Therapist in 1960s Mexico"](#) by Stanley Krippner, Chacruna Institute
- ["The Peyote Effect: From the Inquisition to the War on Drugs"](#) by Alexander S. Dawson

QUOTES

"Each patient attends a marathon-type group session of 22 hours on average, in which the aforementioned psychodysleptics are used as psychotherapeutic aids. Eight days after this session, the patient participates in a group therapy, with an average of 8 hours, in which psychodysleptics are not administered and in which the experiences contained in the session are enunciated and confronted.

Between therapy and the next session, that is to say, over the course of the next three weeks, the patient has an average of one individual interview per week with the therapist. In addition, they attend as observers to some other session or enter the second part of another session as well, but as participants." (**Roquet – Los Alucinógenos de la Concepción Indígena a una Nueva Psicoterapia, 66**)